



Smart Speaker

Intelligent audio solutions for your home

Smart speakers with inbuilt AI assistants such as Alexa, Google Assistant, and Siri have become central to a smart home. The market is being flooded with options for smart speakers, and Amazon Alexa and Google Assistant-powered smart speakers are possibly the most widely used. Apple's Siri-powered speakers are growing in popularity too, but are a distant third favourite. Audio performance and voice recognition are critical, and what we really test for.

WINNER: AMAZON ECHO (4TH GENERATION)

Amazon's flagship Echo smart speaker has gone under a complete design overhaul in 2020 with a new spherical design that replaced the old cylindrical shape. Apart from an aesthetic overhaul, the Amazon Echo also comes with improved audio, a built-in Zigbee smart home hub, and a spanking new AZ1 processor that reduces the time it takes Alexa to respond to voice commands. The speaker features a bold bass response that isn't too overpowering and a wide soundstage. The sound from the speaker is even more room-encompassing than the previous iteration, enveloping users in an auditory bubble, as long as your room isn't extremely large. The smart speaker can control a staggering number of smart devices and can easily provide general information such as sports scores, weather, play music from a variety of streaming services, make voice calls to other Alexa devices and much more. Alexa is pretty easy to talk to and the microphone picks up the user's voice even when loud music is playing in the background – we're talking 10 feet away with music playing loudly, without you needing to shout! The speaker also sets itself apart due to its massive library of third-party skills that simply aren't found in the competition. Overall, it ticks more boxes than its competitors that released this year and ended up convincingly winning the Digit Zero1 award for the best performing smart speaker in 2020.



Amazon Echo (4th generation)

Price: ₹9,999



RUNNER UP: GOOGLE NEST AUDIO

If you're a fan of Google Assistant, then the Nest Audio smart speaker may interest you, as it only falls short of the Echo in a few tests. Let's start with the positives. The speaker is capable of streaming music, answering questions, setting timers and alarms, just like the Echo. However, it lags considerably behind the Amazon Echo when it comes to its portfolio of smart home devices it can control. That aside, the speaker picks up voice very well, answers questions much more accurately, sounds more natural and has pretty decent audio quality that fills up a normal-sized room with relative ease. However, the sound quality does lack a certain punch and weightiness that is present in the Echo. Overall, this is an easy to operate smart speaker that comes with Google Chromecast inbuilt, and is backed by the impressive Google Assistant. It lags behind the winner when it comes to audio quality and supported smart home devices.



Mi Smart Speaker

Price: ₹3,499



Google Nest Audio

Price: ₹7,999

BEST BUY: MI SMART SPEAKER

Priced at ₹3,499, the Mi Smart Speaker is a decent value for money purchase, especially for first-time smart speaker buyers. The speaker is audibly louder than smart speakers in a similar price range such as the Amazon Echo Dot 3rd generation and Google Nest Mini. It's still powered by the Google Assistant, so in terms of what it supports and what features it has it's identical to Google's Nest range. While the microphone performance is slightly lacklustre with the speaker having some difficulty picking up our voice consistently from 10 feet away, the audio quality is pretty decent. The bass does overpower the mids at times, however, the speaker is loud, and sounds full-bodied in comparison to smart speakers in the same price range. This wins it our Best Buy award in the Smart Speaker category.

– Dhriti Datta